Despite such differences, both sides have struggled to move ahead in their bilateral relations. In 1983 Joint Commission was set up to increase cooperation in various sectors like industry, culture, education, tourism, information and scientific exchanges. Both reiterated to develop peaceful relations on the basis of mutual cooperation. This positive development got a jolt due to acquisition of Harpoone missiles by Pakistan and supply of arms and training to Sikh militants. In 1984, after the assassination of Indira Gandhi when her son Rajiv Gandhi became the PM he took up measures to improve relations with Pakistan. Another Joint Commission was set up to look into various aspects of bilateral cooperation.

In 1985, both countries pledged not to attack each other's nuclear installations. However, again relations got a blow and Rajiv Gandhi postponed his visit to Islamabad. In 1987, virtually the relations got ruptured due to heavy troop movements on both sides and clashes in the undemarcated region of the Siachen Glacier as well as acquisition of sophisticated weapons by Pakistan from USA. In 1988, with the restoration of democracy in Pakistan and assumption of the office of PM by Benazir Bhutto, relations again eased. Rajiv Gandhi visited Islamabad an signed three accords pertaining not to attack each others nuke installations, promotion and development of relations in the sectors like art, culture, archeology, education, mass media and sports and avoidance of double taxation on income derived from international air transport to facilitate airlines operation to both countries. India also facilitated Pak's entry into Commonwealth from which Pak had withdrawn in 1972. Again relations got strained as Pakistan tried to develop nuke capacity. Bhutto visited Pyongyang to negotiate a deal for exchange of missiles and missile technology from North Korea. In 1989, there was slight improvement of relations with several cooperative measures in economic, medical, agricultural and cultural fields and easing of travel facilities as well as decision for coordinated patrolling by both sides. The years 1990 and 1991 also saw some more improvements and high-level meetings between the two countries. However, there were clashes between Pak troops and Indian army in September in the Kemi area of Poonch sector, and in October 1991 there was a Pak attack on an Indian outpost in Kargil. In 1992,